I did not know then that I was giving my opponents an idea. On 8 July 1996, the government issued an erratum, changing the word ‘reinvestigation’ in its order to ‘further investigation’.

Some groups, which had by now used the ISRO spy case for their publicity, were upset that their façade of the crusade in national interest was coming apart. One such was a group called All India Lawyers Forum that filed a criminal review petition challenging the CJM’s order. A man called P A Viswambharan, who claimed to be a retired IB man, followed suit, with Kallada Sukumaran, the director general of prosecution of the Kerala Government representing him. The Kerala High Court dismissed all these petitions. On 18 July 1996, the union government announced in Parliament that the ISRO espionage case has been closed.

But this clutch of Kerala Police Officers just could not let it end this way, for they had to now face the music. They kept repeating portions from an order of a Kerala High Court bench comprising K Sreedharan and B N Patnaik on 13 January 1995. On a writ filed by an NGO called Niyamavedi, some videos of our interrogation were produced before the court. Curiously enough, nobody knew or acknowledged the source of the videos (later it became clear that it was the IB). Watching one of the videos, a judge had prematurely observed that it was ‘crystal clear’ that espionage had happened.

What he didn’t know was that the Maldivian women, whose ‘confession’ formed the basis of this observation, had told the CBI that their interrogators had held sheets of paper with names of people to be identified in the confession statement, just above the camera (My name, especially, was a tongue twister for the Maldivians). The discerning CBI officers found that the eyes of the accused where hovering above the camera while they uttered the names.

The same order, incidentally, also had some uncharitable remarks against the CBI. This, the premier investigating agency, got expunged by the Supreme Court via an order dated 5 April 1995.

Now, after the Kerala Government issued the order for further investigation, I challenged it in the Kerala High Court. Here, the bench